

Note that 0 is the only zero of the polynomial x^3 . Also, from Fig. 2.7, you can see that 0 is the x -coordinate of the only point where the graph of $y = x^3$ intersects the x -axis. Similarly, since $x^3 - x^2 = x^2(x - 1)$, 0 and 1 are the only zeroes of the polynomial $x^3 - x^2$. Also, from Fig. 2.8, these values are the x -coordinates of the only points where the graph of $y = x^3 - x^2$ intersects the x -axis.

From the examples above, we see that there are at most 3 zeroes for any cubic polynomial. In other words, any polynomial of degree 3 can have at most three zeroes.

Remark : In general, given a polynomial $p(x)$ of degree n , the graph of $y = p(x)$ intersects the x -axis at atmost n points. Therefore, a polynomial $p(x)$ of degree n has at most n zeroes.

Example 1 : Look at the graphs in Fig. 2.9 given below. Each is the graph of $y = p(x)$, where $p(x)$ is a polynomial. For each of the graphs, find the number of zeroes of $p(x)$.

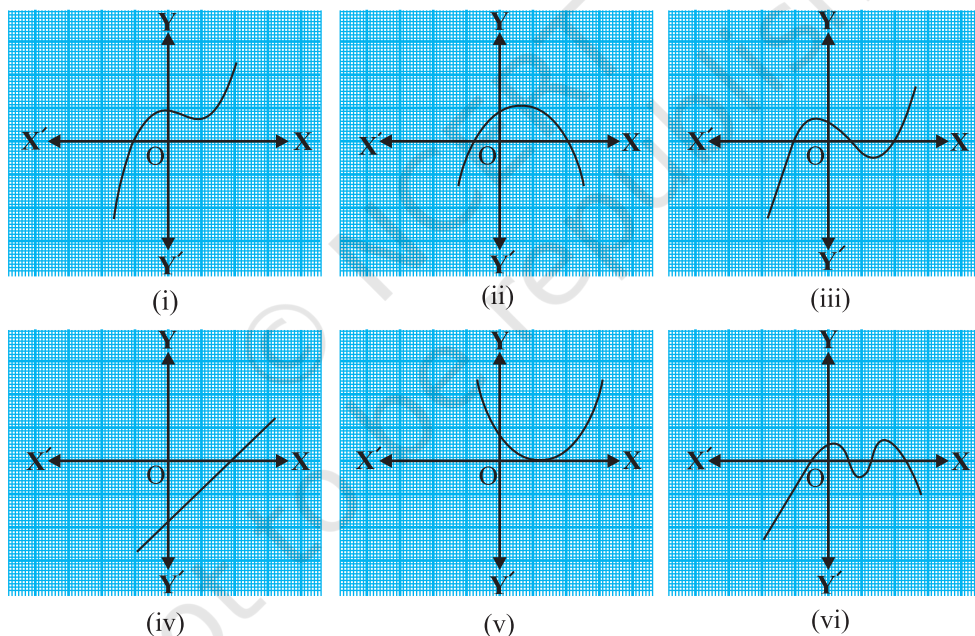


Fig. 2.9

Solution :

- (i) The number of zeroes is 1 as the graph intersects the x -axis at one point only.
- (ii) The number of zeroes is 2 as the graph intersects the x -axis at two points.
- (iii) The number of zeroes is 3. (Why?)

$$\text{i.e.,} \quad \text{sum of zeroes} = \alpha + \beta = -\frac{b}{a} = \frac{-(\text{Coefficient of } x)}{\text{Coefficient of } x^2},$$

$$\text{product of zeroes} = \alpha\beta = \frac{c}{a} = \frac{\text{Constant term}}{\text{Coefficient of } x^2}.$$

Let us consider some examples.

Example 2 : Find the zeroes of the quadratic polynomial $x^2 + 7x + 10$, and verify the relationship between the zeroes and the coefficients.

Solution : We have

$$x^2 + 7x + 10 = (x + 2)(x + 5)$$

So, the value of $x^2 + 7x + 10$ is zero when $x + 2 = 0$ or $x + 5 = 0$, i.e., when $x = -2$ or $x = -5$. Therefore, the zeroes of $x^2 + 7x + 10$ are -2 and -5 . Now,

$$\text{sum of zeroes} = -2 + (-5) = -7 = \frac{-(7)}{1} = \frac{-(\text{Coefficient of } x)}{\text{Coefficient of } x^2},$$

$$\text{product of zeroes} = (-2) \times (-5) = 10 = \frac{10}{1} = \frac{\text{Constant term}}{\text{Coefficient of } x^2}.$$

Example 3 : Find the zeroes of the polynomial $x^2 - 3$ and verify the relationship between the zeroes and the coefficients.

Solution : Recall the identity $a^2 - b^2 = (a - b)(a + b)$. Using it, we can write:

$$x^2 - 3 = (x - \sqrt{3})(x + \sqrt{3})$$

So, the value of $x^2 - 3$ is zero when $x = \sqrt{3}$ or $x = -\sqrt{3}$.

Therefore, the zeroes of $x^2 - 3$ are $\sqrt{3}$ and $-\sqrt{3}$.

Now,

$$\text{sum of zeroes} = \sqrt{3} - \sqrt{3} = 0 = \frac{-(\text{Coefficient of } x)}{\text{Coefficient of } x^2},$$

$$\text{product of zeroes} = (\sqrt{3})(-\sqrt{3}) = -3 = \frac{-3}{1} = \frac{\text{Constant term}}{\text{Coefficient of } x^2}.$$

Example 4 : Find a quadratic polynomial, the sum and product of whose zeroes are -3 and 2 , respectively.

Solution : Let the quadratic polynomial be $ax^2 + bx + c$, and its zeroes be α and β . We have

$$\alpha + \beta = -3 = \frac{-b}{a},$$

and
$$\alpha\beta = 2 = \frac{c}{a}.$$

If $a = 1$, then $b = 3$ and $c = 2$.

So, one quadratic polynomial which fits the given conditions is $x^2 + 3x + 2$.

You can check that any other quadratic polynomial that fits these conditions will be of the form $k(x^2 + 3x + 2)$, where k is real.

Let us now look at cubic polynomials. Do you think a similar relation holds between the zeroes of a cubic polynomial and its coefficients?

Let us consider $p(x) = 2x^3 - 5x^2 - 14x + 8$.

You can check that $p(x) = 0$ for $x = 4, -2, \frac{1}{2}$. Since $p(x)$ can have at most three zeroes, these are the zeroes of $2x^3 - 5x^2 - 14x + 8$. Now,

$$\text{sum of the zeroes} = 4 + (-2) + \frac{1}{2} = \frac{5}{2} = \frac{-(-5)}{2} = \frac{-(\text{Coefficient of } x^2)}{\text{Coefficient of } x^3},$$

$$\text{product of the zeroes} = 4 \times (-2) \times \frac{1}{2} = -4 = \frac{-8}{2} = \frac{-\text{Constant term}}{\text{Coefficient of } x^3}.$$

However, there is one more relationship here. Consider the sum of the products of the zeroes taken two at a time. We have

$$\begin{aligned} & \{4 \times (-2)\} + \left\{(-2) \times \frac{1}{2}\right\} + \left\{\frac{1}{2} \times 4\right\} \\ &= -8 - 1 + 2 = -7 = \frac{-14}{2} = \frac{\text{Coefficient of } x}{\text{Coefficient of } x^3}. \end{aligned}$$

In general, it can be proved that if α, β, γ are the zeroes of the cubic polynomial $ax^3 + bx^2 + cx + d$, then

$$\begin{aligned}\alpha + \beta + \gamma &= \frac{-b}{a}, \\ \alpha\beta + \beta\gamma + \gamma\alpha &= \frac{c}{a}, \\ \alpha\beta\gamma &= \frac{-d}{a}.\end{aligned}$$

Let us consider an example.

Example 5* : Verify that 3, -1, $-\frac{1}{3}$ are the zeroes of the cubic polynomial $p(x) = 3x^3 - 5x^2 - 11x - 3$, and then verify the relationship between the zeroes and the coefficients.

Solution : Comparing the given polynomial with $ax^3 + bx^2 + cx + d$, we get

$a = 3, b = -5, c = -11, d = -3$. Further

$$p(3) = 3 \times 3^3 - (5 \times 3^2) - (11 \times 3) - 3 = 81 - 45 - 33 - 3 = 0,$$

$$p(-1) = 3 \times (-1)^3 - 5 \times (-1)^2 - 11 \times (-1) - 3 = -3 - 5 + 11 - 3 = 0,$$

$$\begin{aligned}p\left(-\frac{1}{3}\right) &= 3 \times \left(-\frac{1}{3}\right)^3 - 5 \times \left(-\frac{1}{3}\right)^2 - 11 \times \left(-\frac{1}{3}\right) - 3, \\ &= -\frac{1}{9} - \frac{5}{9} + \frac{11}{3} - 3 = -\frac{2}{3} + \frac{2}{3} = 0\end{aligned}$$

Therefore, 3, -1 and $-\frac{1}{3}$ are the zeroes of $3x^3 - 5x^2 - 11x - 3$.

So, we take $\alpha = 3, \beta = -1$ and $\gamma = -\frac{1}{3}$.

Now,

$$\alpha + \beta + \gamma = 3 + (-1) + \left(-\frac{1}{3}\right) = 2 - \frac{1}{3} = \frac{5}{3} = \frac{-(-5)}{3} = \frac{-b}{a},$$

$$\alpha\beta + \beta\gamma + \gamma\alpha = 3 \times (-1) + (-1) \times \left(-\frac{1}{3}\right) + \left(-\frac{1}{3}\right) \times 3 = -3 + \frac{1}{3} - 1 = \frac{-11}{3} = \frac{c}{a},$$

$$\alpha\beta\gamma = 3 \times (-1) \times \left(-\frac{1}{3}\right) = 1 = \frac{-(-3)}{3} = \frac{-d}{a}.$$

* Not from the examination point of view.